

# Game Design

Game design compiles psychology, storytelling, art, and systems thinking to engage players. Create a meaningful experience for the player.

# Principles

## 1. Player-Centered Design

- i. How should the player feel
- ii. Is the game intuitive/confusing
- iii. Is it fun/frustrating
- iv. Playtesting is important

## 2. Create a Core Gameplay Loop

- i. Example: Action → Reward → Upgrade → Repeat
- ii. Good loops keep players engaged
  - a. simple, but fun to repeat

### 3. Balance

- i. An unfair game does not feel fun
- ii. There is a difference between difficulty and unfairness
- iii. Too easy created boredom
- iv. Flow is a psychology concept about keeping players in between boredom frustration

### 4. Clear goals and Feedback

- i. It is important for a player to know what they can and should be doing
  - a. How well they are doing
- ii. Some Feedback examples are
  - a. sound effects
  - b. visual cues
  - c. progress indicators

## 5. Meaningful choices

- i. trade-offs - gain one thing, lose another
- ii. multiple strategies
- iii. choices that affect the outcome

## 6. Progression and rewards

- i. Examples: Levels, skills, upgrades, better gear, narrative progression

## 7. simplicity

- i. easy to learn, but still has depth

## 8. Immersive

- i. cohesive theming

## Game Design tips I received:

1. Be wary of the user having to repeat commands
  - i. This can become tedious to have to retype, especially if the command is fairly long
  - ii. Some solutions:
    - a. Scripts/Macros/Aliases to shorten user input. Also command history
    - b. Make commands more expressive so that players have to think about them more
    - c. Pressure: Enemies continue to move and mistyping a command can have consequences

2. Make the learning of the language feel like mastery of it
3. Reward for creative use of commands
4. Good Feedback
  - i. Make sure to have visual and/or audible feedback
5. Add Variant loops
  - i. Combat that focuses on fast decisions
  - ii. Exploration
  - iii. Puzzles
  - iv. Have resource management



6. Make sure the story/narrative has reason for the command line
7. Decide whether the game should be fast or slow paced
8. Suggestion given: command chaining. Not sure if applicable now, but may be interesting in the future.

## **I asked about a way to make the combat to be more interesting:**

1. change commands from move foreword or attack to dash foreword, lunge goblin, circle enemy, retreat west, guard
  - i. decrease typing and increase meaning
2. Intent based combat
  - i. decision making instead of just typing fast

3. commands should persist, not be one off
  - i. define behavior
  - ii. have commands last for a duration
  - iii. otherwise players will spam
4. Cooldown/commitment
5. Enemies should demand different commands to defeat

